EDIGHA FRANCISCA LITERARY SOLUTIONS

Amazon Book Listing Review

Fifty one checks across the eight zones of an Amazon book listing. Each check names what to look at, why it matters, and what to test. Work through them in order, or use the checklist as a review after a book has been published and before it is relaunched.

EDIGHA FRANCISCA · AUTHOR GROWTH STRATEGIST

01 Title and subtitle

7 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 01

The title is legible at thumbnail size

Amazon shows titles in a result list at a small font size. Test the title at phone width, in the results list, not on the full product page. If it cannot be read there, it cannot be read by the browser.

- [ ] CHECK 02

The title does not repeat the subtitle

A title that repeats its own subtitle wastes one of the two slots. Each should carry a distinct search phrase, not two versions of the same phrase.

- [ ] CHECK 03

The subtitle contains a search phrase

The subtitle is indexed by Amazon search. If it says only "A Novel," it contributes nothing. A subtitle carrying a genre phrase or reader intent term contributes a search term.

- [ ] CHECK 04

The title does not violate Amazon's title guidelines

Amazon excludes certain characters and phrases from titles: promotional language, all caps, repeated punctuation. A title that breaks these guidelines can be suppressed or edited without notice.

- [ ] CHECK 05

The series name appears in the title field

A series reader searches for the series, not the book. If the series name is missing from the title field, the book does not appear in that search and the reader cannot find book two.

- [ ] CHECK 06

The title reads clearly to a stranger

Show the title, without context, to someone who has not read the book. If they cannot say what kind of book it is, the title is not carrying its weight. The cover must do the rest.

- [ ] CHECK 07

The title and subtitle are consistent with the cover

A reader sees the cover, the title and the subtitle together. If any of the three suggests a different genre, the reader feels the mismatch and moves on. All three should agree.

02 Cover

6 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 08

The cover reads at 160px width

Amazon displays covers at approximately 160 pixels wide in search results. Shrink the cover to that width. If the genre cannot be recognised, the cover is not doing its job in the place most readers will see it.

- [ ] CHECK 09

The cover matches the genre conventions

Every genre has visual conventions. A psychological thriller is read one way, a cozy mystery another, a literary novel another. A cover that breaks the convention must do so deliberately, and most do not.

- [ ] CHECK 10

The title on the cover reads at thumbnail size

A title that is elegant at full cover size can become unreadable at thumbnail size. Check the title text itself, inside the cover image, at 160 pixels wide. It should still be legible.

- [ ] CHECK 11

The author name appears on the cover

A reader who has finished one book and is looking for another relies on the author name to recognise the next one. A cover without the author name is a cover that does not travel between titles.

- [ ] CHECK 12

The cover image meets Amazon's technical requirements

Amazon recommends a cover of at least 1,000 pixels on the longest side, RGB colour, and a 1.6:1 height to width ratio. A cover that does not meet these guidelines will appear blurred or cropped.

- [ ] CHECK 13

The cover does not contain misleading imagery

A cover that promises a genre the book does not deliver attracts the wrong reader, who leaves as soon as they read the description. Misleading imagery costs a sale and gains a review that reflects the confusion.

03 Description

8 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 14

The first sentence sells the promise

The first sentence decides whether the second is read. If it summarises the plot, it is asking the reader to care before they know what the book is for. If it delivers the promise, the reader continues.

- [ ] CHECK 15

The description confirms the cover

The cover makes a promise. The description either confirms it or contradicts it. When the two disagree, the reader feels the disagreement and leaves, often without knowing which of the two they distrusted.

- [ ] CHECK 16

The description is free of HTML errors

A description pasted from a manuscript can carry stray tags, odd line breaks, or lost paragraph breaks. Amazon strips some tags but not all, and the result is a page that looks unmanaged even when the writing is good.

- [ ] CHECK 17

The description is the right length

A description that is too short does not give the reader enough to decide. A description that is too long loses them before the end. Test the description on a phone screen, where most readers will meet it.

- [ ] CHECK 18

The description uses bold and italics deliberately

Amazon allows limited formatting in the description. Bold and italic can be used to shape reading, or they can be used to shout. A description that bolds every other word is unreadable, however strong the underlying copy.

- [ ] CHECK 19

The description contains no external links

Amazon removes external links from descriptions and can suppress a listing that attempts to include them. A description that says "visit my site" may look harmless, but it can cost the listing its visibility.

- [ ] CHECK 20

The description has been read on a phone

Most Amazon readers are on mobile. A description that reads well on a desktop can become a wall of text on a phone. Read the description on a phone before deciding it is finished.

- [ ] CHECK 21

The description has been reviewed in the last year

A description written for a launch is often the wrong description a year later. The book's reviews have arrived, its audience has clarified, and the language of the market may have shifted. Re-read the description at least once a year.

04 Categories and keywords

7 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 22

Three categories are chosen, not defaulted

Amazon places a book in up to three categories. If they were not chosen deliberately, they were chosen by the platform. That is a positioning decision made by a system, not by a strategist.

- [ ] CHECK 23

At least one category is specific enough to win

A broad category buries a new book among hundreds of thousands of titles. A specific category places it among hundreds. Only one of those gives a book any chance of appearing in a bestseller list.

- [ ] CHECK 24

The categories match the book's genre

A book can win a category and still reach the wrong reader. The category is a statement about who the book is for. If the category signals a genre the book is not, the reader who arrives is the reader who leaves.

- [ ] CHECK 25

All seven backend keyword fields are filled

Amazon provides seven backend keyword slots per book. Each empty slot is a search phrase the book cannot be found for. Seven distinct, relevant phrases is the correct standard.

- [ ] CHECK 26

The backend keywords do not repeat the title or subtitle

Amazon already indexes the title and subtitle. Using the backend fields to repeat them wastes the slots. Each backend field should carry a phrase the title does not already carry.

- [ ] CHECK 27

The backend keywords cover three reader intents

Readers search by mood, by trope, by setting, by comparison, and by format. Filling every keyword with the same kind of phrase limits the book to one kind of search. At least three of the seven fields should cover a different intent.

- [ ] CHECK 28

The backend keywords contain no prohibited terms

Other authors' names, other book titles, and phrases that misrepresent the book are excluded from metadata. A keyword that violates Amazon's terms of service can suppress the listing.

05 Reviews and social proof

6 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 29

The book has at least fifteen reviews

Fifteen reviews is the threshold below which Amazon's algorithm treats a book as unproven, and above which it begins to include the book in "also bought" and category recommendations. Below fifteen, most books are invisible to the recommendation engine.

- [ ] CHECK 30

The average rating is above 4.0

A rating below 4.0 is treated as a warning by most readers. A book at 4.2 with fifty reviews converts far better than a book at 3.8 with two hundred. The threshold matters more than the count.

- [ ] CHECK 31

The most recent review is within the last three months

A book whose most recent review is over a year old reads as inactive. Amazon's algorithm weights recency, and so do readers. If the last review is old, request a review from a recent reader.

- [ ] CHECK 32

The top review reflects the book's actual promise

The most helpful review sits at the top of the review section. If it praises the book for something the description did not promise, it is telling the next reader to expect something different from what the cover and page have said.

- [ ] CHECK 33

Editorial reviews are present on the listing

Amazon's Editorial Reviews section, if used, appears near the description and adds authority. A line of praise from a respected publication or author is one of the strongest signals a listing can carry.

- [ ] CHECK 34

Reviews have not been purchased or exchanged

Amazon actively removes purchased reviews and can suppress a listing found to have them. The temptation is real, the cost is greater. Reviews that arrive naturally are slower but they do not risk the book's visibility.

06 A plus Content

6 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 35

A plus modules exist on the listing

A plus Content occupies the space below the description and above the reviews. A listing without A plus modules is a listing that is missing the largest block of presentational real estate Amazon offers.

- [ ] CHECK 36

The first A plus module extends the description

The first module is the one most readers see. If it repeats what the description already said, it wastes the space. If it extends the argument with a new image or a new sentence, the reader has a reason to stay.

- [ ] CHECK 37

The A plus modules are visually consistent with the cover

A plus modules in a different colour scheme or typeface to the cover break the reader's sense of what the book is. The modules should feel like a continued visual argument, not a separate advertisement.

- [ ] CHECK 38

The A plus modules contain no broken images

Amazon's A plus builder occasionally fails to render images after an edit or a listing transfer. A broken image in an A plus module is a visible failure that a reader will notice before they notice the copy.

- [ ] CHECK 39

The A plus modules have been reviewed since publication

A plus content built at launch often reflects the book the author thought they had written. A year of reader reviews clarifies what the book is. The modules should be updated to reflect what readers have found.

- [ ] CHECK 40

The A plus modules read well on a phone

A plus Content designed for desktop can become unreadable on mobile, where most readers will meet it. Test the modules on a phone screen before signing off on the design.

07 Author page and catalogue

6 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 41

The author page is claimed and live

Amazon Author Central is free and takes minutes to set up. A book published without a claimed author page is a book with no face behind it, and a reader who has finished one title has nowhere to go to find a second.

- [ ] CHECK 42

The biography names the kind of book the author writes

A reader who has finished a book arrives at the author page with one question: what does this author write? A biography that opens with a degree or a city does not answer it. A biography that opens with the genre does.

- [ ] CHECK 43

Every published title appears on the author page

Amazon sometimes fails to link a title automatically, especially for books published under a previous pen name, or reissued through a different publisher. A missing title is a reader who cannot find the next book.

- [ ] CHECK 44

A series is grouped as a series

A series that is not grouped tells the reader nothing about the reading order. Book one can appear next to book three, with no indication that book two exists. Grouping is a small change with a large effect.

- [ ] CHECK 45

The author page was updated within the last year

A page that has not moved in a year reads as inactive, even when the author is not. The biography, the photograph, and the catalogue order should be reviewed at least once a year.

- [ ] CHECK 46

The follow button has a reason behind it

The follow button is the only asset on an author page that compounds. The biography and catalogue should give the reader a reason to press it, which they do only when the page says there will be a next book.

08 Pricing, formats and launch windows

5 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 47

The Kindle price is within the genre's range

Every genre has a price band readers expect. A psychological thriller at $12.99 is read as expensive next to titles at $4.99. A cozy mystery at $4.99 is read as cheap next to titles at $9.99. Price is a positioning decision as much as a value decision.

- [ ] CHECK 48

More than one format is available

Kindle, paperback, hardcover, audiobook. Each format reaches a different reader. A book available only in Kindle is a book invisible to a reader who only reads paperback, and to a reader who only listens.

- [ ] CHECK 49

The audiobook is narrated well, if it exists

An audiobook with a poor narrator costs more in reviews than it earns in sales. The audiobook sample on the listing is the only place a reader can hear the narration before purchase. Listen to it, as a stranger would.

- [ ] CHECK 50

The book was launched in the New Releases window

Amazon's New Releases list is the highest visibility window of all, and it closes after thirty days. A book that was published quietly and never appeared in New Releases has lost one of the two windows the platform offers.

- [ ] CHECK 51

The listing has been reviewed in the last six months

A book's listing goes stale. Categories shift, prices change in the market, and reviews accumulate. A listing that was correct at launch is often not correct a year later. The listing is a living thing, not a stone tablet.